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Library Column: Food for Fines library campaign helps our local communities



George Williams



George Williams Associated Press

Springtime at the branches of the Latah County Library District means one thing to a lot of library users - Food for Fines. For two weeks, April 13-27, late fees on any library materials owned by the Latah County Library District can be paid by bringing nonperishable food items to any of the seven Latah County libraries. Fees will be forgiven at the rate of \$2 for every nonperishable food item and all of the food collected will go to local food banks. Food will only be accepted for the payment of late fees on items owned by the Latah County Library - if you have any fees for lost or damaged items, or if you have fees on items owned by other VALNet libraries, you can't pay them with food.

The big change this year with Food for Fines is that we have decided to increase the amount of fees forgiven for each article of food donated. In the past we have only forgiven \$1 worth of late fees in exchange for each donated food item. Because of inflation in the past couple of years, we've been finding even the least expensive cans of food now cost more than \$1. Because of this, we're now forgiving fees at the rate of \$2 per item.

We run the Food for Fines campaign every year for a couple of reasons. For one thing, we like to give our patrons an alternative way of taking care of their late fees other than having to bring in money. Patrons with late fees on their library accounts are blocked from using some of the online services offered through the catalog - they can't use their account to renew their checkouts or to place holds. Accounts just work better when late fees are paid off and sometimes food donations are more manageable than cash.

More importantly, though, we run our Food for Fines campaign because it helps our communities. The Latah County Library District operates libraries in Bovill, Deary, Genesee, Juliaetta, Moscow, Potlatch and Troy. In the past five years, our Food for Fines campaigns have collected over 3,750 pounds of food for food banks in these communities. Just like last year, our local food banks need help because of economic conditions.

So please come in to your local library during our Food for Fines campaign and help your community by bringing in food for your local food bank. If you have late fees, we'll be happy to forgive them and if you don't have any late fees, we'll still

accept any food you'd like to contribute.

George Williams is the access services manager at the Latah County Library District.

